WHEN THE WORRY LINES APPEAR

From religious polarisation and caste divide to data privacy and climate, India stands at a critical juncture as it tries to meet challenges, old and new. A look into how Indians perceive key issues the country faces today

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In a country like India where growth is inextricably linked with the functioning of its various public institutions, perception plays a critical role. It is how narratives are built and public opinion shaped. From the proposed introduction of a Uniform Civil Code and the Hindenburg report against the Adani Group to broader themes like caste and gender equality, the INDIA TODAY Mood of the Nation (MOTN) Survey, 2023 offers important insights into not just how Indians perceive key challenges before the country today, but also their collective aspirations and vision for the nation.

The overall findings paint a complex picture. For the first time, more than a third of the respondents (36.6 per cent) are not confident about the functioning of the four pillars of democracy—legislature, executive, judiciary and media. What is consistent, however, is the perception that more than any other arm, it's the judiciary that plays the most important role in upholding democratic norms—though fewer people (27.8 per cent) hold that opinion today than those in January 2022 (34 per cent). The confidence in the media has eroded too, from 20.3 per cent to 12 per cent in the same period. Fewer people also feel free to express their views on politics and religion (45.6 per cent) this time than in August 2022 (49.8 per cent). That another 23.5 per cent say they feel free to express an opinion on politics but not on religion is a direct reflection of the rising polarisation. Finally, more people are worried about the state of the Indian democracy—almost half (49.8 per cent) of the respondents express apprehensions on the subject this MOTN, up from 42 per cent in January 2021.

The communal situation is another worry. Fewer respondents (41.4 per cent) in the current survey feel that communal harmony under the NDA government has improved than